A Documentary History of Art

VOLUME II

Michelangelo and the Mannerists

The Baroque and the Eighteenth Century

Selected and Edited by

ELIZABETH GILMORE HOLT



friends and often to himself, he had no other fault than that of indifference and of a liking for change. It can be said that no painter ever had more fame than he during his life as well as after his death. His paintings which have risen to a very high price are today still eagerly sought after. They may be seen in Spain, in England, in Germany, in Prussia, in Italy, and in many places in France, especially in Paris. Also one must concede that there are no more agreeable pictures for small collections than his. They incorporate the correctness of drawing, truth of color and an inimitable delicacy of brushwork. He not only excelled in *gallant* and rustic compositions, but also in subjects of the army, of marches, and bivouacs of soldiers, whose simple and natural character makes this sort of pictures very precious. He even left a few historical pieces whose excellent taste shows well enough that he would have been equally successful in this genre if he had made it his principal objective.

Although Watteau's life was very short, the great number of his works could make one think that it was very long, whereas it only shows that he was very industrious. Indeed, even his hours of recreation and walking were never spent without his studying nature and drawing her in the situations in which she seemed to him most admirable.

The quantity of drawings produced by his study and which have been chosen to be engraved and to form a separate work is a proof of this truth.[6]

DENIS DIDEROT

[Denis Diderot (1713-1784), whom his father had destined for the clergy, received his education from the Jesuits. Because of a stubborn preference for letters rather than canonical law, he was forced to support himself as best he could by translations and lessons. His first original work, *Philosophical Thoughts* (*Pensées Philosophiques*,

[6] [See our *fig.* 19.]

1746), was burned for its attack on Christian dogma and morals. For the expression of an atheistic, materialistic philosophy in *The Letter on the Blind* (1749), Diderot was thrown into prison. There he began that gigantic task, the *Encyclopedia*, which occupied him for twenty years and which associated him with Voltaire, D'Alembert, Rousseau, Helvetius and others. His unbridled curiosity led him into every field of thought and he endeavored to free knowledge from its dogmatic and doctrinal prejudices. In spite of vigorous opposition from Church and State, the *Encyclopedia* appeared in 1772. Although Diderot enjoyed great popularity and exercised great influence in France, he was denied official recognition. Catherine of Russia granted him a pension, and at her invitation he went to St. Petersburg (1773-1774).

In 1737, with the establishment of the *Salons*, or annual expositions, art theory was freed from the guardianship of the Academy and opened to the public. This change resulted in art criticism by men more or less informed on the subject. Especially characteristic of this tendency is Diderot, who in his *Salons* (1765) assumes a role similar to a journalistic critic and expresses the current opinion in France that "it is the chief business of art to touch and to move, and to do this by getting close to 'nature.'" (See Gilbert and Kuhn, *A History of Esthetics*, New York, 1939, p. 208.)]

from the master, the academy, the school, and even from the antique.

SALON OF 1765

Three Sketches by Greuze[5]

A sketch is generally more spirited than a picture. It is the artist's work when he is full of inspiration and ardour, when reflection has toned down nothing, it is the artist's soul expressing itself freely on the canvas. His pen or skillful pencil seems to sport and play; a few strokes express the rapid fancy, and the more vaguely art embodies itself the more room is there for the play of imagination. In singing we must listen to the words of a song; but I can put any feelings I please into a well-composed symphony, and as I know better than anyone else what touches my heart, I am generally more affected by my own interpretation of the music according to the mood I am in, whether grave, or tender, or gay, than I should be by the interpretation of anyone else. There is the same sort of difference between a sketch and a picture; in the latter the subject is fully worked out for us to look at; in the former I can imagine so many things which are only suggested.

The Beloved Mother. The composition of *The Beloved Mother* is so natural and simple that the careless observer might think that he could have done as well himself, and that it did not require much thought or cleverness. I will only answer such persons by saying, "Yes, of course you would have grouped all these children around their mother, lavishing their caresses on her, and you would

[5] Jean Baptiste Greuze (1725-1805), received his early training in Lyons. He came to Paris in 1750 and in 1755 was admitted conditionally to the Academy. He did not become a member until 1769 and then was admitted only as a genre painter. His popularity was due to the moralizing representation of the simple, honest virtues of country people in such pictures as *Reading the Bible* (1755), *The Village Wedding* (1761), *The Father's Curse* and a series depicting the good and bad ways of life. The sentiment of his pictures is similar to that found in Rousseau's *Nouvelle Héloïse*.

have represented one of them crying because he was not noticed more than the others; and you would, of course, have introduced the husband coming in at the moment, looking cheerful and happy at having such a wife, and proud of being the father of so many children. And, of course, you would have remembered to bring the grandmother into the scene."

Let us describe the composition. It is in the country; in a large, low room we see a bed, in front of the bed a cat sits on a footstool, while the beloved mother is lying back on a couch with all her children round her. There are six at least; the youngest is in her arms, the second clings to her on one side, and the third on the other; the fourth has climbed up the back of the couch and is kissing her forehead; the fifth kisses her cheek; the sixth, standing up, hangs his head down and looks dissatisfied. The mother's countenance is full of joy and tenderness, yet she seems as if rather overcome by the caresses and presence of such a number of children, which would be too much for her if continued long. It is the attitude and expression of the mother lying with her head a little back, and weakness manifesting itself in spite of happiness and tenderness, that gives its charm and originality to this one figure taken apart from the rest of the composition. In front of this charming group lies a child's bodice and a little cart. Farther back in the room sits the grandmother in her armchair near the fireplace; she has a truly grandmotherly cap and dress, and is smiling at the scene before her. More to the left in the foreground a dog is barking with joy, as if he partook of the general happiness. Farther still to the left the husband appears, just come from shooting; he stretches out his arms and throws his body slightly back as he laughs; he is a fine, well-grown young man, and is evidently proud and happy at the sight of his group of children; his dog is at his side; farther back is a basket of linen, and we catch a glimpse of a maid leaving the room.

The picture is excellent as a work of art and as a portrait of what a happy home should be. It preaches this lesson to every sensible man: "Keep your family in comfort, and take care to have a happy home to which to return."

The Ungrateful Son. Imagine a room only lighted by the door when it is open or by a square opening above the door when it is shut. Look round, and the room will reveal to you nothing but poverty. Still there is a well-furnished bed in the right corner; on the same side in front is a large and comfortable black leather chair; the father of the ungrateful son is sitting there; near the door is a low cupboard, and a little table by the old man's side with a bowl of soup. Although the eldest son might have stayed at home to help his old father, he has enlisted, and is now come with an old soldier to ask his family for some money. His father is indignant. He reproaches his son for forgetting his duties to his father and mother, and the unnatural son returns insulting words to these severe reproofs. He stands erect in the center of the picture, his hat on his head, with an angry, insolent air; his right arm is raised on the side next to his father, and above the head of one of his sisters, and with his hand he makes menacing gestures. The good old man, who had been a kind but not too indulgent father, tries to stand up, but one of his daughters who is kneeling before him catches hold of his coat tails to prevent him. The young scoundrel is surrounded by his eldest sister, his mother, and one of his little brothers. His mother puts her arms round him, but he brutally pushes her away and tries to escape from her embrace. The poor mother is overcome with grief; she and the eldest sister try to interpose between the young man and his father and to hide them from each other. The sister has seized her brother's coat as if to say, "O, what are you doing; you drive away your mother and you threaten your father; kneel down, rather, and ask their pardon." The little brother meanwhile is crying and rubbing his eyes, and hanging on to his tall brother's arm, tries to drag him from the house. The youngest of all stands behind the father's chair, looking puzzled and frightened. At the other side of the picture the old soldier who had enlisted and accompanied the young man walks away with his head down and his sword under his arm, and his back to the scene. I forgot to say that a dog in the foreground adds to the tumult by barking.

Everything is clearly thought out and well grouped in this sketch; the grief of the mother and her tenderness for a spoiled child, the old man's indignation, the different actions of the sisters and of the little children, the insolence of the youth, and the old soldier's feeling of shame, as he shrugs his shoulders and goes off, are all well depicted; and the barking dog is one of those minor accessories which Greuze knows how to invent. Yet this sketch, though very fine, does not please me as much as the following:

The Bad Son's Punishment. He has been to the wars, he comes back, but at what a moment. His father has just died. Everything is much changed in the old home. There was poverty before; now there is grief and want. There is no mattress on the bed where the old man is laid out. The light falls from an opening, but only on his face, the rest is in shadow. At his feet on a straw chair is a burning taper and a vase of holy water. The eldest daughter lies back in the old leather chair in an attitude of despair, one hand resting on her forehead, the other raised and still holding the crucifix which she gave her dying father to kiss. One of the little children has hidden its face on her bosom. The other, with hands and arms stretched out, seems to gather its first impressions of death. The younger sister, sitting between the window and the bed, cannot realize that she has no longer a father; she bends toward him, she seems trying to meet his last looks; she raises her arm, and her half open mouth exclaims, "My father, my father, don't you hear me any more?" The poor mother stands against the wall near the door; her knees give way under her, she is overcome with grief. This is the sight which meets the eyes of the ungrateful son. He comes forward, he is on the threshold; he has lost the leg with which he spurned his mother, the arm which he raised against his father is maimed. His mother meets him at his entrance; she is silent, but with her hand points to the corpse as if to say: "See what you have done."

The ungrateful son is struck with amazement; his head falls forward and he strikes his forehead with his hand. What a lesson is here depicted for fathers and children! The minor details are as carefully thought out as the

principal figure. I can imagine from the book lying on the table before the eldest daughter that it was her sad task to read the prayers for the dying, while the phial by the book probably contained a cordial. The same dog appears as in the other sketch, and he seems doubtful whether he is to recognize this maimed fellow as the son of the house or to take him for a beggar.

I do not know what effect this short and simple description of the sketch will produce on others, but for my own part I could not write it without emotion. But as no one makes anything quite perfect, even in these beautiful sketches I find something to criticize; first, I think that the mother's gesture is not quite natural at the moment. Would she not have covered her eyes with one hand as if to hide from her sight both her son and her husband's corpse, while she pointed to the latter with her other hand? It seems to me that this gesture would have added to the pathos, and the lower part of the face would have sufficiently shown the violence of her grief. Secondly, I think that in one trifling detail Greuze has gone wrong, though he is usually very particular; the vessel for holy water and the asperser are such as the church would put at the foot of the bier, but in a cottage it would only be a jug of water with a piece of box blessed on Palm Sunday.[6]

For the rest I consider that these sketches are masterpieces of composition; there is nothing labored or artificial about them, but the interest is simple and striking, yet appeals to all. But nowadays there is so little real feeling for art that perhaps these sketches will never be painted as pictures, and if they were, Boucher would sooner sell fifty of his commonplace indecent puppets than Greuze these two sublime compositions. But now with regard to Greuze's style, let me ask you a few questions. First, what is true poetry? Secondly, is there poetry in these two last sketches by Greuze? Thirdly, what difference is there between this poetry and that of the sketch of *The Tomb of Artemisia*? Fourthly, of two painted cupolas, of which one would be

[6] The sketch described here was a study for the picture now in the Louvre (our *fig.* 20).

recognized as painted, and the other would be mistaken for a real cupola, which is the finer work of art? And lastly, of two letters written, we will say, from a mother to a daughter—the one full of fine sentiments, eloquent and pathetic, which everyone admires but which no one would take for a real letter, the other so simple and natural that everyone takes it for a letter really written by a mother to a daughter—tell me which is the one we ought to admire; and also which was the more difficult to write? You may be certain that I shall not go further with these questions and answers, for it would lead me to writing a book within a book.

COUNT OF CAYLUS

[Count of Caylus (1692–1765) was a member of a distinguished military family. His mother, a niece of Madame de Maintenon, wrote the valuable *Souvenirs* of Louis XIV's court edited by Voltaire. After a military career, Count Caylus' interest in archaeology led him to travel for the purpose of studying and collecting in Italy, Greece and other countries. On his return to Paris he wrote numerous books, the most influential probably being *Recueil d'antiquités égyptiennes, étrusques, grecques, romaines et gauloises* (1752–55). He learned drawing and engraving in order to illustrate his publications and thereby gained admission as an Honorary Member to the Royal Academy of Painting and Sculpture where he played an active role in establishing the standards of classicism. His interest was not limited only to ancient art. He arranged for the engraving of the drawings in the Royal Collections, which were published as a part of the *Chalcographie* (1806?). He wrote a biography of the contemporary sculptor, Edmé Bouchardon, and gave a critical summary of Watteau's life and work to the Academy. In other writings he gives a vivid picture of life in Paris at that time.]